PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

Vicksburg — A House Divided

Why One River City Decided a War

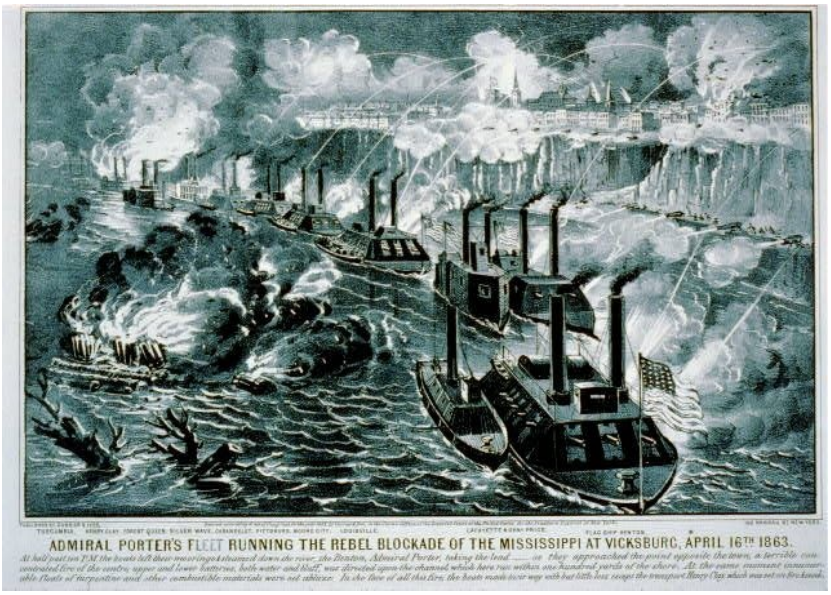
Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about Vicksburg — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Geography shapes history. Use the map and the sources to explain why Vicksburg mattered far beyond its size

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · 1863 — Running the batteries at Vicksburg



Vicksburg sat on bluffs high above a hairpin bend in the river — its guns could hit any boat that tried to pass. That is why the Union had to take the city, not just sail by it

"Admiral Porter's fleet running the rebel blockade of the Mississippi at Vicksburg, April 16, 1863" — lithograph, Currier & Ives, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · ABRAHAM LINCOLN · 1863 — "The Father of Waters"

"The Father of Waters again goes unvexed to the sea. … The job was a great national one, and let none be banned who bore an honorable part in it."
— President Abraham Lincoln, letter, August 1863. Public domain

— President Abraham Lincoln, letter, August 1863. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · READ THE GEOGRAPHY

Using the lesson and the image, explain why Vicksburg's location made it so important. What could its guns do, and why couldn't the Union just sail past?

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · WHAT CONTROL MEANT

When Lincoln said “the Father of Waters again goes unvexed to the sea,” he meant that —

- ☐ A. the river had flooded
- ☐ B. the Union now controlled the entire Mississippi, splitting the Confederacy
- ☐ C. the Confederacy had captured New Orleans
- ☐ D. the war was over

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · SIGNIFICANCE

Vicksburg fell on July 4, 1863 — the day after Gettysburg. In two or three sentences, explain why historians call this single week the turning point of the war. What did each victory accomplish?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · MAKE THE JUDGMENT

Some historians argue Vicksburg mattered more than Gettysburg, because it permanently split the Confederacy. Do you agree? Take a position and defend it with evidence from the lesson.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — Vicksburg — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Vicksburg sat on… Its guns could… so the Union had to…"

QUESTION 2: **Correct — B. the Union now controlled the entire Mississippi, splitting the Confederacy**

Right. With Vicksburg taken, the Union controlled the whole Mississippi, so Union boats could travel it freely ("unvexed") — and the Confederacy was split in two.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Gettysburg… while Vicksburg…. Together they…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I think ___ mattered more because…"